'Arun can travel alone though,' said the woman beside me, and somehow I felt grateful to her for saying that. I had already forgiven her for lying: and besides, I had taken an instinctive dislike to Satish's mother.

'Well, be very careful Arun,' said Satish's mother looking sternly at me through her spectacles. 'Be very careful when your mother is not with you, and never talk to strangers!'

I looked from Satish's mother to the woman who had given me tea and sweets, and then back at Satish's mother.

'I like strangers,' I said.

Satish's mother definitely **staggered** a little, as obviously she was not used to being contradicted by small boys. 'There you are, you see! If you don't watch over them all the time, they'll walk straight into trouble. Always listen to what your mother tells you,' she said **wagging** a fat little finger at me. 'And never, never talk to strangers.'

I glared **resentfully** at her, and moved closer to the woman who had befriended me. Satish was standing behind his mother, **grinning** at me, and delighting in my clash with his mother. Apparently he was on my side.

The station bell clanged, and the people who had till now been **squatting** resignedly on the platform began **hustling** about.

'Here it comes,' shouted Satish, as the engine whistle **shrieked** and the front lights played over the rails.

The train **mowed** slowly into the station, the engine hissing and sending out waves of steam. As it came to a stop, Satish jumped on the footboard of a lighted compartment and shouted, 'Come on, Arun, this one's empty!' and I picked up my suitcase and made a dash for the open door.

We placed ourselves at the open windows, and the two women stood outside on the platform, talking to us. Satish's mother did most of the talking.

'No don't jump on and off moving trains, as you did just now,' she said. 'And don't stick your heads out of the windows, and don't eat any rubbish on the way.' She allowed me to share the benefit of her advice, as she probably didn't think my 'mother' a very capable person. She handed Satish a bag of fruit, a cricket bat and a big box of chocolates, and told him to share the food with me. Then she stood back from the window to watch how my 'mother' behaved.

I was smarting under the **patronizing** tone of Satish's mother, who **obviously** thought mine a very poor family: and I did not intend giving the other woman away. I let her take my hand in hers, but I could think of nothing to say. I was conscious of Satish's mother staring at us with hard, beady eyes, and I found myself hating her with a firm, unreasoning hate. The guard walked up the platform, blowing his whistle for the train to leave. I looked straight into the eyes of the woman who held my hand, and she smiled in a gentle understanding way. I leaned out of the window then, and put my

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